



For Staff

Misogyny and Violence Against Women and Girls (VAWG)

Comprehensive guidance for recognising and responding to gender-based harm in educational settings

Content Warning These scenarios cover sexual violence and abuse.

These are reference scenarios and response scripts, not a training course. Use them to check how to respond, or to prepare for a conversation. They do not replace the school's safeguarding training, policy or the DSL's advice on a specific case.

They contain descriptions of misogyny, sexual harassment, sexual violence, image-based abuse, domestic abuse and so-called honour-based abuse, including examples of abusive language. Some of it may be difficult to read, particularly if it connects with your own experience or that of someone close to you.

- You can read them in sections, take a break, or step away at any point.
- If this raises something personal, you can speak in confidence to your line manager, a senior colleague you trust, or the school's Employee Assistance Programme, if it has one, or **Education Support** (free, confidential, 24/7 on 08000 562 561).
- If you have a question about how this guidance applies to a situation you are dealing with, speak to your school's Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL).

If reading this makes you worried about a child now, do not wait until you have finished reading: speak to the DSL or a deputy straight away. If a child is in immediate danger, call 999.

Immediate danger or possible risk to life: call 999 when it is needed, stay with the child, and summon the DSL or a deputy. Don't delay action to work through the steps. The 90-second Pause is for once immediate safety is secured, to stop an impulsive or investigative response. **Go to the Quick Reference Card.**

National Context

In July 2024 the National Police Chiefs' Council and the College of Policing described **violence against women and girls as a national emergency**. On **18 December 2025** the Government published ***Freedom from violence and abuse***, its cross-government VAWG strategy, with the ambition of **halving VAWG within a decade**, and describes VAWG as a national emergency. The strategy places education at the centre of prevention and early intervention.

KCSIE 2026 adds content on VAWG and misogyny, retitles child-on-child abuse to include harassment and violence, and asks schools to recognise **the escalatory nature of misogyny** and the benefits of early identification.

Scenario Overview

This scenario addresses misogynistic attitudes and behaviours toward female students and staff, including sexist language, sexual harassment, objectification, and gender-based violence. It applies KCSIE 2026 and the Government's VAWG strategy, ***Freedom from violence and abuse*** (December 2025), through the RESPOND workflow to provide comprehensive guidance for educational settings.

Classification

Child-on-Child Abuse (including harassment and violence) / Emotional Abuse / VAWG

Moderate to High Severity

Urgent: Raise With DSL Under School Policy

Legal and Statutory Framework (England): KCSIE 2026; Working Together to Safeguard Children 2026; Equality Act 2010; RSHE statutory guidance (July 2025, in force September 2026); ***Freedom from violence and abuse*** (December 2025)

Context: Any setting (classroom, online, social spaces, boarding, extra-curricular)

Why This Matters: Headline Figures

92%

of girls said sexist name-calling happens a lot or sometimes to them or their peers

Ofsted, June 2021

49%

of 13 to 17 year olds in a relationship experienced violent or controlling behaviour

Youth Endowment Fund, 2024

58%

of young people had seen pornography depicting strangulation before 18

Children's Commissioner, survey May 2025, published August 2025

23.4%

of female teachers reported misogyny from a pupil in the last year

NASUWT, 2026

Full figures, sources and notes on interpretation are in **The Evidence: What the Data Shows**, below.

Critical Understanding

Misogyny is often normalised as "banter" or dismissed as "boys being boys." KCSIE 2026 is clear that sexual harassment and sexual violence should never be passed off as "banter", "just having a laugh", "a part of growing up" or "boys being boys", and that failing to challenge it can lead to a culture that normalises abuse. This scenario addresses attitudes, behaviours, and language that demonstrate contempt, prejudice, or hostility toward girls and women, recognising that:

- Misogyny can escalate to sexual harassment and violence
- It intersects with other forms of discrimination (race, disability, sexual orientation, faith)
- Online influence (misogynistic influencers, the "manosphere", incel culture) is a growing concern, and can harm boys and young men as well as girls
- Cultural sensitivity must be balanced with child protection obligations
- This is about systemic culture change, not just individual incidents

Balance. VAWG is gendered, and KCSIE recognises girls are more likely to be victims. Anyone can experience sexual violence or harassment, including boys and lesbian, gay, bisexual or gender-questioning students, who may find it harder to report. Most boys and young men are respectful. The aim is to challenge misogynistic ideas and behaviour, not to stigmatise boys as a group (*Freedom from violence and abuse*; RSHE statutory guidance).

How RESPOND Works in This Scenario

RESPOND is powered by **ACT: Active Intervention** (inaction is not neutral), **Contextual Safeguarding** (harm happens in peer groups, places and online spaces) and **Trauma-Informed Practice** (safety before emotion before thinking). The steps are taught in order but work as a **helix**: you may loop back, hold at a step, or go straight to Notify if a child is at risk. For a child, safeguarding is **relational**; for the adults around them, it is also **systemic**. See *The RESPOND Helix* section to watch the steps move.

Step	RESPOND tool	In this scenario
● Recognise	4 Ps Context Scan; Escalation of Unseen Harm	Misogyny escalates. Notice the "banter" before it becomes harassment
● Engage	4Ds of Active Intervention; TED questions	Challenge what you witness, if safe; listen to what is disclosed
● Support	Safety check first; "Your calm is contagious"	Support, not investigation
● Pause	90-second grounding; Three Lenses (Risk, Rights, Resources)	Check your own bias before acting
● Offer	If in doubt, N before O	Explain what happens next; model the alternative
● Notify	Context First notification	You don't need certainty: you need to share your concern
● Document	GOLD standard	If it's not written down, it didn't happen

The One Chance Rule: a disclosure may be a child's only attempt to seek help. Make it count.

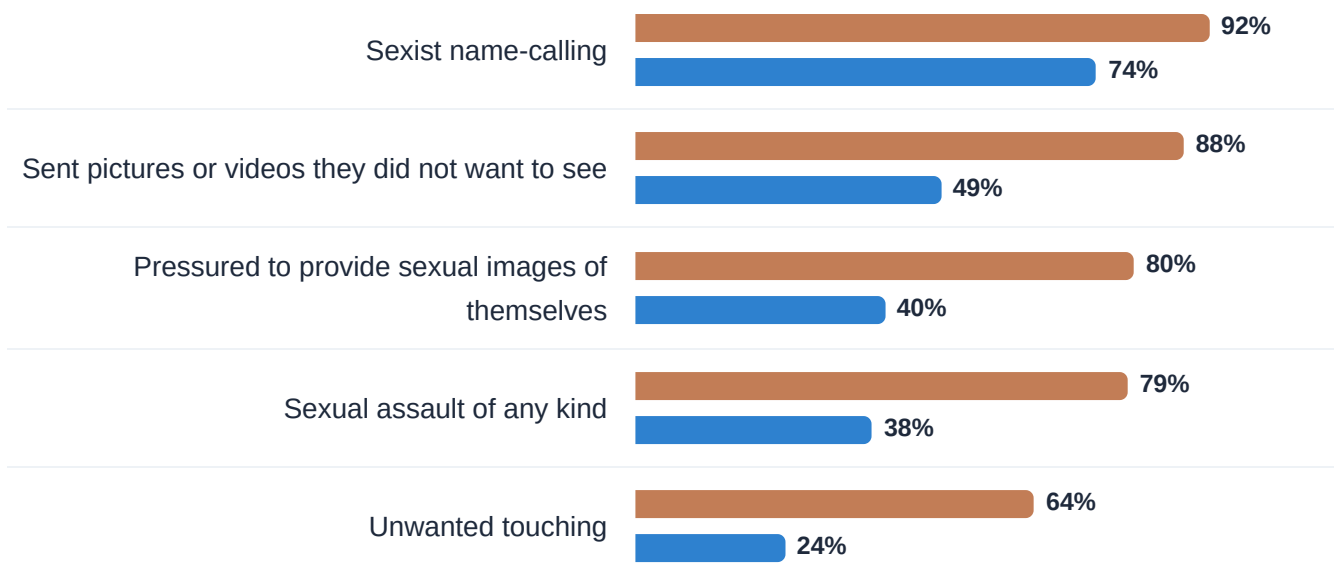
The Evidence: What the Data Shows

Every figure below is taken from the named source and was checked in September 2026. Surveys measure different things in different ways, so read each figure with its source note rather than comparing them directly.

In Schools: What Students Say Happens to Them or Their Peers

Percentage saying each happens "a lot" or "sometimes" to them or their peers.

■ Girls ■ Boys



Source: Ofsted, *Review of sexual abuse in schools and colleges*, June 2021 (inspectors visited 32 schools and colleges and spoke to more than 900 young people; the percentages come from the review's survey, answered by about 800 girls and about 800 boys). These are perceptions of how often things happen among peers, not individual rates of victimisation. The review concluded that schools should act as though sexual harassment and online sexual abuse are happening, even when there are no specific reports.

86%

of violent incidents against 10 to 15 year olds (where the victim could describe the offender) involved a pupil at the victim's own school

Crime Survey for England and Wales, year ending March 2018

Teenage Relationships

49%

of 13 to 17 year olds who had been in a relationship in the past year experienced some form of violent or controlling behaviour

Youth Endowment Fund, *Children, Violence and Vulnerability 2024* (survey of 10,000 13 to 17 year olds, England and Wales)

20%

said they were pressured or forced into sexual activity against their will

Youth Endowment Fund, *Children, Violence and Vulnerability 2024* (survey of 10,000 13 to 17 year olds, England and Wales)

27%

said they were made to feel afraid to disagree with their partner

Youth Endowment Fund, *Children, Violence and Vulnerability 2024* (survey of 10,000 13 to 17 year olds, England and Wales)

17%

had explicit images or videos
of themselves shared online

Youth Endowment Fund, *Children,
Violence and Vulnerability 2024*
(survey of 10,000 13 to 17 year
olds, England and Wales)

Percentages are of the 27% of respondents who had been in a relationship in the past year.

Online Content and Image-Based Abuse

70%

of 16 to 21 year olds had
seen pornography before the
age of 18; the average age
of first seeing it was 13

Children's Commissioner for
England (survey of 16 to 21 year
olds, survey May 2025, published
August 2025)

58%

had seen pornography
depicting strangulation
before they turned 18

Children's Commissioner for
England (survey of 16 to 21 year
olds, survey May 2025, published
August 2025)

59%

first saw pornography online
by accident, compared with
35% who sought it out

Children's Commissioner for
England (survey of 16 to 21 year
olds, survey May 2025, published
August 2025)

13%

of children aged 9 to 17 had
had an experience with a
nude deepfake, estimated at
about four in a class of 30

Internet Matters, *The new face of
digital abuse* (Opinium survey,
June 2024; published October
2024)

Misogynistic Influencers

41%

of young men aged 16 to 24 had a favourable view of a prominent misogynistic influencer, compared with 12% of young women

HOPE not hate, Focaldata poll of 2,040 16 to 24 year olds, January 2024

56%

of boys aged 6 to 15 had a negative view of the same influencer; 17% had a positive view

YouGov Children's Omnibus, September 2023

5x

children exposed to content from misogynistic influencers were five times more likely to see hurting someone physically as acceptable if they apologised afterwards

Women's Aid research, cited in its response to the VAWG strategy, December 2025

Recommendation systems can bring this content to boys with ordinary interests: in a 2024 experiment, accounts interested only in gym, sport and gaming were recommended manosphere content within 2 to 17 minutes (DCU Anti-Bullying Centre; see **Staff Guide 102: Online Influence and the Manosphere**). In line with the RSHE statutory guidance, this page does not name individual influencers. In surveys, most boys view that content negatively: challenge the ideas, not the student.

Staff

23.4%

of female teachers reported misogyny from a pupil in the last year, up from 17.4% in 2023

NASUWT survey of over 5,000 teachers, 2026

21.95%

of all teachers reported discriminatory language from a pupil in the last year, including sexist, racist and homophobic language

NASUWT survey of over 5,000 teachers, 2026

National Picture

20%

of all police-recorded crime in England and Wales in 2022/23 was VAWG-related: over one million offences

NPCC and College of Policing, *VAWG National Policing Statement*, July 2024

3x

children with disabilities are three times more likely to be abused than their peers

Keeping Children Safe in Education 2026

KCSIE 2026 also states that girls are more likely to be the victims of sexual harassment and sexual violence, and that it is more likely to be perpetrated by boys. Anyone can be affected, including boys and lesbian, gay, bisexual or gender-questioning students, who may find it harder to report.

Reading These Figures

- **No reports does not mean no problem.** KCSIE 2026 and Ofsted both say harm may simply not be being reported.
- **A rise in reports can be good news.** It often means students trust the school to act.
- **Behind every percentage is a child.** Use the data to shape culture and prevention; respond to each individual through RESPOND.
- **Check before reuse.** Newer editions of these surveys may have been published since September 2026.

Sources: Check the Figures Yourself

- Office for National Statistics, *The nature of violent crime in England and Wales: year ending March 2018*
- Ofsted, *Review of sexual abuse in schools and colleges* (June 2021)
- Youth Endowment Fund, *Children, Violence and Vulnerability 2024: teenage relationships*
- Children's Commissioner for England, pornography research (survey May 2025; published August 2025)
- Internet Matters, *The new face of digital abuse* (October 2024)
- HOPE not hate, Focalddata poll of 2,040 16 to 24 year olds (January 2024)
- YouGov Children's Omnibus (September 2023)
- Women's Aid, response to the VAWG strategy (18 December 2025)
- NASUWT, *Misogyny in schools hits new high* (April 2026)
- NPCC and College of Policing, *VAWG National Policing Statement* (July 2024)
- Department for Education, *Keeping Children Safe in Education 2026*
- Dublin City University Anti-Bullying Centre, *Recommending Toxicity* (summary report, 2024)

The RESPOND Helix: How the Steps Move

RESPOND is taught in a line, Recognise to Document, because sequence gives structure under pressure. In practice it moves as a helix. The first dimension is the steps themselves: you may loop back, hold at a step, or go straight to Notify. The second is time and severity: each turn sits higher as a concern develops. The third is context: a concern involving several children, places or platforms traces a wider spiral.

Relational and Systemic

For a child, safeguarding is **relational**: it happens through people they trust. For the adults around them, it is also **systemic**: the steps, records and shared decisions that make sure what a child tells one person reaches the people who can help.

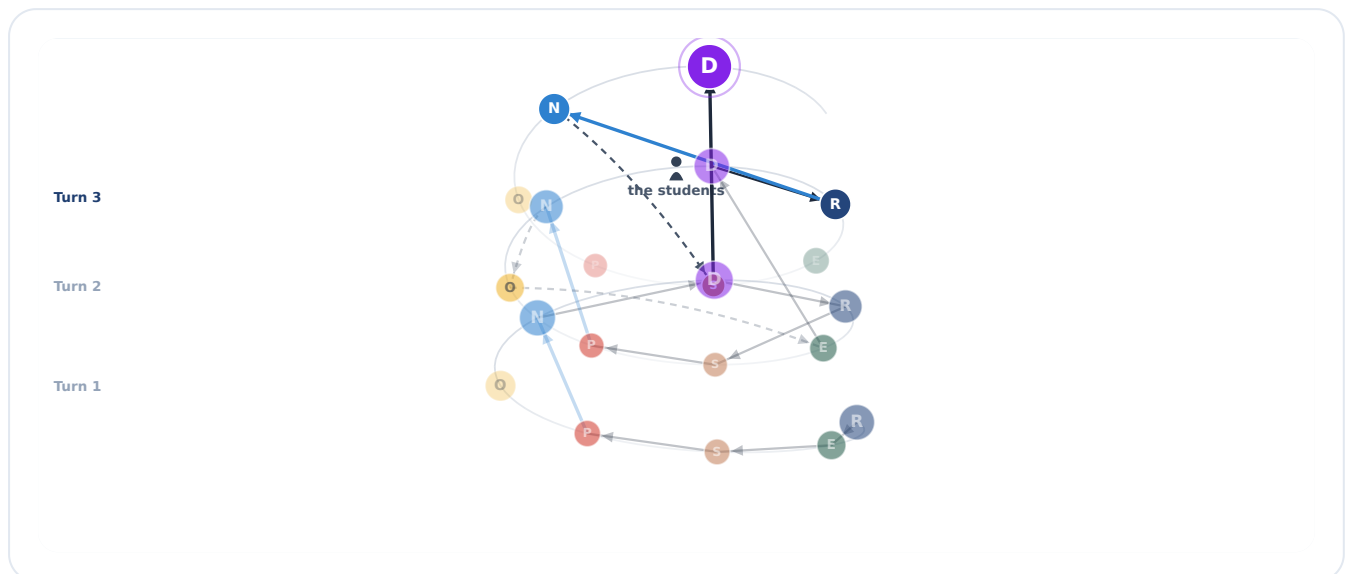
Relational is why children tell. Systemic is why telling works.

The RESPOND steps follow the same shape: Recognise, Engage and Support are relational; Pause is the bridge; Offer, Notify and Document are the systems steps. Neither works alone. Relationship without the system becomes secrecy, which is why staff never promise to keep a disclosure to themselves. The system without relationship becomes process that children do not trust enough to use. When you share information, be open with the child about what you are sharing and why.

See It Move

Two examples: a boy displaying misogyny and a girl experiencing it. Then see a wider spiral with several students at once, and what happens when steps are skipped. (A boy drawn into harmful content online is worked through in Staff Guide 102.)

This is a still image of the interactive RESPOND Helix. Open the web version of this guide to step through the examples; every example is also written out in full below.



▼ Read the helix demonstration as text

Sequence

How RESPOND is taught.

1. **The seven steps:** RESPOND is taught in this order, Recognise to Document, because sequence gives structure under pressure. Recognise, Engage and Support are the relational steps; Pause is the bridge; Offer, Notify and Document are the systems steps.
2. **But practice is not a line:** In practice a concern rarely moves in a straight line. You may loop back, hold at a step, or go straight to Notify. Choose one of the examples to see how the steps move.

Boy displaying misogyny

A Year 10 boy whose misogynistic comments escalate over a term. He is a child too: the helix wraps around him and the girls affected.

1. **Turn 1: a comment in class:** In a lesson, a Year 10 boy says women "shouldn't be in charge" and that girls who disagree are "hysterical". Some classmates laugh. Recognise: it is aimed at the girls in the room, and one is visibly uncomfortable.
2. **Turn 1:** Engage: Direct, calmly, if it is safe to do so: "That's not how we talk about people here." Later, privately, TED: "Tell me where you've heard that."
3. **Turn 1:** Support: check in briefly with the girls affected. Connection before correction applies to him as well.
4. **Turn 1:** Pause: Three Lenses. Low risk for now, but it echoes content he may be watching online. Do not get drawn into a debate about the ideology.
5. **Turn 1:** Notify: pass it to the DSL as soon as is practicably possible, through the school's usual system. Offer can wait for this turn.
6. **Turn 1:** Document: GOLD, with his exact words and who heard them. This record is what lets the next turn begin higher up.
7. **Turn 2: a named girl (two weeks later):** A girl tells her tutor he has been commenting on girls' bodies in a group chat and calling her names. Because the lesson was recorded, the DSL can link the two. Recognise: this is now sexual harassment, with a named girl affected.
8. **Turn 2:** Support her first: believe her, safety first, and ask what would help her feel safe in lessons and at break.
9. **Turn 2:** Pause: Three Lenses. Her safety and wellbeing; his rights and needs as a child too. Do not investigate or ask to see the chat.
10. **Turn 2: N before O:** Notify: the DSL, today. The DSL decides the response under the school's child-on-child abuse procedures. If in doubt, N before O.
1. **Turn 2:** Offer, once the DSL has decided: education and consequences for him; support, and a say in what happens next, for her. Model the alternative: respect is expected, not optional.
2. **Turn 2: loop back:** Loop back to Engage with him. The relationship still matters: name the behaviour, not the boy, and keep the door open.
3. **Turn 2:** Document: GOLD for each conversation, recorded separately for each student.
4. **Turn 3: risk:** He shares an image of a girl in his year that has been altered to look sexual. Recognise: this is a child protection matter.
5. **Turn 3: straight to Notify:** Go straight from Recognise to Notify: tell the DSL immediately. Do not view, copy, forward or delete the image.
6. **Turn 3:** Support: the girl may not know yet. The DSL decides how and when she and her parents are told, and what support she needs.
7. **Turn 3:** Document: GOLD, as soon as is practicably possible. Describe what you were told, never the image itself.

Girl experiencing misogyny

A Year 9 girl on the receiving end of misogyny, over a term. Each turn is higher: the same steps, at greater urgency.

1. **Turn 1: "just banter":** A Year 9 girl laughs off being called "a 6 out of 10" by boys at break: "it's just banter". Recognise: many girls say this happens so often it is not worth reporting.
2. **Turn 1:** Engage: TED. "Tell me what happens at break." Don't minimise it, and don't push her.
3. **Turn 1:** Support: tell her it isn't OK and it isn't her fault, and that she can come back to you at any time.

4. **Turn 1:** Notify: pass it to the DSL, even though she says she's fine. Patterns are only visible when things are passed on.
5. **Turn 1:** Document: GOLD, with her exact words.
6. **Turn 2: a pattern (three weeks later):** Her PE teacher notices she has stopped changing for PE and sits alone. Because the first comment was recorded, the DSL can see the link.
7. **Turn 2:** Engage: a trusted adult checks in privately. She says boys have been rating girls' bodies in the corridor outside the changing rooms.
8. **Turn 2: loop back:** Loop back to Recognise: new information changes the picture. This is sexual harassment, and it is affecting her.
9. **Turn 2:** Support: safety first. Ask what would help: another place to change, a trusted adult, a plan for break times.
10. **Turn 2:** Pause: Three Lenses. Her rights include a say in what happens next, but you cannot promise to keep it secret.
1. **Turn 2: N before O:** Notify before Offer: the DSL, as soon as is practicably possible.
2. **Turn 2:** Offer, once the DSL has decided: work out with her what support she wants and what she would like to happen. Model the alternative: she should not have to change her life to avoid them.
3. **Turn 2:** Document: GOLD, with dates and what each adult has noticed.
4. **Turn 3: disclosure:** Weeks later she tells you a boy has been pressuring her to send nude images and says he will spread a rumour if she doesn't.
5. **Turn 3:** Engage: listen, and use the disclosure script: "I believe you, and I'm taking what you've told me seriously. This is not your fault. I'm going to help keep you safe, and I'll explain what happens next."
6. **Turn 3: straight to Notify:** Go straight to Notify: the DSL, immediately. Do not ask to see any messages or images.
7. **Turn 3:** Support: stay with her while help comes, and be honest that you have to pass this on.
8. **Turn 3:** Document: GOLD, her exact words, as soon as is practicably possible.

Wider spiral

One incident, several people at once: a Year 10 group chat rating girls. Each strand is its own spiral.

1. **Three strands:** A girl tells you boys in a Year 10 group chat are rating girls in the year. A single-child concern traces a tight spiral; this one is wider: the girls rated, the boys who posted, and everyone else in the chat.
2. **At the same time:** Support the girls who have been rated, while engaging the boys who posted. The chat is still being recognised: is it active, and who else is in it?
3. **At the same time:** Pause for each person. The chat goes straight to the DSL: do not view, screenshot, forward or save anything.
4. **Joined up:** Notify: one joined-up picture to the DSL, who coordinates the response and any contact with parents or other agencies.
5. **Different speeds:** The strands move at different speeds. Education and consequences for the boys follow the DSL's decisions; bystanders are shown how to speak up next time, if it is safe to do so. Every strand ends in Document.

When it breaks

The same Year 9 girl, when steps are skipped.

1. **Turn 1:** The same girl laughs off being rated at break. Recognise happens.
2. **Pause skipped:** The adult agrees it is "just banter" and moves on. Pause is skipped: the adult reacts to how she presents, not to what is happening.
3. **Document skipped:** Nothing is recorded. When her PE teacher later notices she has stopped changing, there is nothing to connect it to. The pattern stays invisible.
4. **Notify skipped:** The concern stays with one adult. Professionals working in isolation, and information not being shared, are recurring findings in serious case reviews.
5. **The helix fragments:** The structure that should wrap around her falls apart. She learns that telling changes nothing, and stops telling. That is how harm escalates unseen.
6. **Put it back together:** Every step taken puts the structure back. Relational is why children tell; systemic is why telling works.

The Helix is described in the RESPOND Safeguarding Operating System (section 5.2). All examples are fictional. Most boys and young men are respectful; the examples show how to respond when harm occurs, not what to expect of boys as a group.

R RECOGNISE: Identify the Concern

Notice physical, emotional, behavioural and contextual cues of misogyny and VAWG.
Trust your instincts: you don't need certainty to act.

The 4 Ps Context Scan

People

Who is involved? Power dynamics? A group, an older student, a friendship or relationship?

Places

Where is it happening?
Changing rooms, corridors, toilets, sports fields, boarding houses, transport

Platforms

Digital element? Group chats, social media, AI tools, image sharing

Patterns

One-off or recurring? Is it getting worse? Are several students or staff affected?

The Escalation of Unseen Harm: How Misogyny Escalates

KCSIE 2026 asks schools to recognise the escalatory nature of misogyny. RESPOND's Escalation of Unseen Harm shows how risk accumulates when early indicators are not acted on. Each stage is a missed opportunity; the earliest is the easiest to interrupt.

1. **Micro-indicators:** sexist "jokes" and "banter" go unchallenged; a girl stops contributing in class
2. **Pattern formation:** repeated comments, "rating" of girls, a group chat with misogynistic content; the targeted student starts avoiding certain people or places
3. **Visible distress:** anxiety, avoiding PE or changing rooms, changes in dress or attendance; no disclosure yet
4. **Significant harm (unspoken):** ongoing harassment, images shared or threatened; no one has asked or created a safe space to tell
5. **Crisis event:** sexual assault, wide distribution of images, or an acute mental health crisis
6. **System breakdown:** school refusal, leaving the school, police involvement, entrenched harm

The Response Threshold: the moment you notice but hesitate is the moment the trajectory can be interrupted.

Manosphere Content

Sigma, mogging, red pill, looksmaxxing? The glossary decodes the terms, and the age-by-age examples show how the same ideas look at ages 4 to 9, 10 to 13 and 14 to 18. Ask "What does that mean to you?" before assuming. See **Staff Guide 102: Online Influence and the Manosphere**.

Observable Behaviours and Language

Language and Communication Indicators

- Using derogatory terms: "slut," "whore," "bitch," "asking for it"
- Making jokes about women's intelligence, abilities, or bodies
- Rating or ranking girls based on physical appearance
- Sharing misogynistic influencer or incel content online
- Dismissing girls' opinions or contributions in class
- Using "rape jokes" or trivialising sexual violence
- Comments that objectify or sexualise female students or staff

Physical and Social Actions

- Unwanted touching or commenting on bodies
- Blocking pathways or physical intimidation
- Creating hostile environments in male-dominated spaces

- Excluding girls from activities or leadership roles
- Making or sharing nudes or semi-nudes (including AI-generated or altered images), or creating "rating" lists
- Following, monitoring, or attempting to control female students
- Behaviours KCSIE 2026 names as potentially criminal: grabbing bottoms, breasts and genitalia, pulling down trousers, flicking bras, lifting up skirts, upskirting

Digital Misogyny

- Group chats with misogynistic content
- Sharing "manosphere" content: misogynistic influencers, content framing women as property or as owing men attention
- Creating fake profiles to harass female students
- Non-consensual image sharing, threats to share, sextortion, or AI-generated "deepfake" nudes
- Coordinated online harassment campaigns
- Algorithmic amplification and repeated exposure to misogynistic content
- Posting harmful content about female students/staff

Systemic/Institutional Indicators

- Gender disparities in discipline (girls over-policed for dress code)
- Male voices dominating classroom discussions
- Stereotypical subject/activity divisions
- Staff dismissing or minimising concerns
- Lack of female representation in leadership
- Absence of gender equality education
- "Boys will be boys" culture tolerated by staff

Impact on Targeted Students

Immediate Effects

- Anxiety, hypervigilance, fear of school spaces

- Academic disengagement or decline
- Self-censorship and reduced participation
- Changes in dress or behaviour to avoid attention
- Social isolation or withdrawal
- Avoidance of specific individuals, locations, or activities

Longer-Term Consequences

- Reduced aspirations and confidence
- Mental health difficulties (depression, anxiety, PTSD)
- Internalised misogyny and self-objectification
- Acceptance of harmful relationship dynamics
- Career limitations and subject choices affected
- Normalisation of gender-based violence

Questions to Consider at Recognition Stage

- **Pattern or Isolated:** Is this an isolated incident or pattern of behaviour?
- **Multiple Involvement:** Are multiple students involved or targeted?
- **Digital Component:** Is there online component requiring digital evidence preservation?
- **Intersectionality:** Does this intersect with other protected characteristics (race, disability, sexual orientation, faith)?
- **Immediate Safety:** Is there immediate safety risk to any student?
- **Radicalisation:** Is there any sign the student may be being drawn into supporting terrorism or terrorist violence? Misogyny alone does not meet this threshold

Documentation at Recognition Stage

Immediate Recording Requirements

- ✓ Date, time, location of incident(s)
- ✓ Specific language or actions observed (verbatim quotes)
- ✓ Names of individuals involved (victim(s) and alleged perpetrator(s))
- ✓ Witnesses present
- ✓ Where any online content is (platform, account, date). Never view, copy or forward nude or semi-nude images; for other online harassment, follow DSL direction on preservation

- ✓ Immediate context and circumstances
- ✓ Your immediate response/actions taken

E ENGAGE: Communicate Effectively

Respond with calm, compassionate listening and create felt safety. Challenge what you witness, if it is safe to do so.

Witnessed Behaviour or a Disclosure? Two Different Responses

- **You witness misogynistic language or behaviour:** use **Active Intervention** and the 4Ds, if it is safe to do so. Inaction is not neutral.
- **A student discloses harassment or abuse:** listen and support. **Do not confront or question the alleged perpetrator.** Do not investigate. Notify the DSL, who decides what happens next.

The 4Ds of Active Intervention

Direct

Address it, if it is safe: "Stop. That comment is sexist."

Distract

Redirect: interrupt, change the activity, call the targeted student away

Delegate

Get help: another adult, on-call, the DSL

Delay

Act later, safely: check in afterwards with the student who was targeted, and tell the DSL

If Observing Misogynistic Behaviour

Immediate Intervention Steps (If It Is Safe to Do So)

Your safety, and the safety of the student being targeted, come first. Only intervene directly if it is safe to do so. If it is not safe (for example a group, a risk of violence, or you are alone), do

not confront: keep your distance, get another adult or use the on-call system, call 999 if anyone is in immediate danger, then record what you saw and tell the DSL.

1. **Interrupt promptly, if it is safe to do so:** "Stop. That language/behaviour is not acceptable."
2. **Name the issue clearly:** "What you just said/did is misogynistic and creates an unsafe environment."
3. **State expectations:** "In this school, we treat everyone with dignity and respect regardless of gender."
4. **Avoid debating:** Don't engage in arguments about whether something is "really" misogyny.

If Receiving a Disclosure

VAWG-Responsive Communication

1. **Thank the student:** "Thank you for telling me. That took courage."
2. **Believe them and take it seriously:** "I believe you, and I'm taking what you've told me seriously. This is not your fault. I'm going to help keep you safe, and I'll explain what happens next." (KCSIE 2026: victims should be reassured they are being taken seriously and will be supported and kept safe.)
3. **Use TED, never "why":** "Tell me what happened." "Explain what you mean." "Describe what that felt like." Avoid "why" questions, leading questions and expressing shock. TED is for understanding, not investigating: ask only what you need to pass the concern on, and never ask a child to describe or show intimate images (UKCIS)
4. **Validate feelings:** "I can understand why this is upsetting. This was not your fault."
5. **Use their words:** Reflect back what they have said without labelling it for them. The DSL, and police where relevant, decide how it is classified. Do not ask leading questions.
6. **Affirm their rights:** "You have a right to feel safe and respected at school."
7. **Explain safeguarding duty:** "I need to report this to keep you and others safe, but I'll explain what happens next."
8. **Offer choices where possible:** KCSIE 2026 says victims should be given as much control as reasonably possible over how the matter proceeds and what support they receive, balanced against the duty to protect others

Language TO USE

- "That behaviour is misogynistic and harmful."
- "Everyone deserves to feel safe and respected here."

- "Gender-based harassment is a serious safeguarding concern."
- "Our school values equality and dignity for all."
- "That was sexual harassment" (when challenging behaviour you have witnessed)
- "This is not acceptable and we will address it."
- "You have a right to learn without being objectified."

Language to AVOID

- "I'm sure they didn't mean it that way."
- "Boys will be boys."
- "Maybe you're being too sensitive."
- "That's just how teenagers talk."
- "You should take it as a compliment."
- "Why didn't you resist/report sooner?"
- "What were you wearing/doing?"
- Minimising as "banter" or "just joking"

Manosphere Content

When a student repeats an influencer's ideas, curiosity before confrontation: name the harm, ask one open question, and don't argue about the influencer. Model rewrites and the NOISE check are in Staff Guide 102. See **Staff Guide 102: Online Influence and the Manosphere**.

When Challenging the Behaviour and the Culture

DO

- Name the behaviour specifically ("That's sexual harassment")
- Challenge promptly and clearly, if it is safe to do so
- Connect to VAWG impact on victims/survivors
- Hold accountable without attacking person
- Set clear behaviour expectations
- Offer education and behaviour change opportunities
- Document thoroughly

DON'T

- Minimise as "banter" or "just joking"
- Use "boys will be boys" language
- Blame victim/survivors in any way
- Accept excuses without challenge
- Allow peer pressure justifications
- Put off acting when it is safe to act, or when you could get help
- Imply shared responsibility

Sample challenging language:

"That comment is misogynistic and harmful."

"Sexual harassment is never acceptable, regardless of intent."

"Girls have a right to learn without being objectified."

"That 'joke' contributes to a culture that enables violence against women."

"We don't tolerate attitudes or behaviours that degrade women."

Cultural Considerations

Balancing Cultural Sensitivity with Child Protection

- Be aware some cultures have different gender norms, **BUT** child safeguarding transcends cultural relativism
- Explain UK legal framework and school values clearly
- Avoid assuming cultural background determines individual attitudes
- Recognise students may face conflicting messages from home/community
- Provide culturally sensitive support while maintaining safeguarding standards
- Frame within universal values: dignity, safety, respect
- **Avoid cultural paralysis:** fear of seeming culturally insensitive must never stop you acting
- Offer independent interpreters when needed. Check that any community or culturally matched liaison does not increase risk, particularly where so-called honour-based abuse is possible



SUPPORT: Maintain Composure

Provide immediate, proportionate help within your role. Your role is support, not investigation.

Safety Check First

- "Are you safe now? Do you need medical attention?"
- Reduce the audience: move somewhere quieter, with fewer people and less noise
- Adapt for SEND, neurodivergent and EAL students: simple language, extra time, visual support or an interpreter where needed
- Connection before correction

Your calm is contagious.

Immediate Support for Targeted Student (VAWG victim/survivor)

Physical Safety Measures

- ✓ If harassment is ongoing and it is safe to do so, move the targeted student away from the situation; if not, get help straight away
- ✓ Provide safe space (private area)
- ✓ Visibility/supervision as appropriate
- ✓ Consider timetable adjustments if needed temporarily. Adjustments should fall on the alleged perpetrator, not the victim: KCSIE 2026 expects the alleged perpetrator to be removed from any shared classes while reports of rape or assault by penetration are assessed
- ✓ Assess transport safety (journey to/from school)
- ✓ Implement temporary alternative arrangements if necessary

Emotional Support (Trauma-Informed)

- ✓ Acknowledge impact without minimising: "What you experienced was serious and wrong"
- ✓ Take seriously and support without investigating: listen, reassure and do not interrogate
- ✓ Access to school counsellor/nurse
- ✓ Peer support networks (where appropriate and safe)
- ✓ Female staff availability (if preferred by student)

- ✓ Privacy and dignity maintained throughout
- ✓ Empower voice: "You have a right to feel safe and respected"

Practical Support

- ✓ Recording without re-traumatisation (avoid repeated storytelling)
- ✓ Documentation shared appropriately (only with those who need to know)
- ✓ Police liaison coordinated by DSL
- ✓ Medical evidence coordination if needed (via SARC)
- ✓ Absence authorised for recovery
- ✓ Academic catch-up support arranged

Ongoing Support Plan

- ✓ Safety plan development (with student input)
- ✓ Regular check-ins scheduled with trusted staff
- ✓ Academic support maintained
- ✓ Reintegration planning (if time out of school needed)
- ✓ Monitoring for retaliation or further incidents
- ✓ Long-term mental health access (referral to Children and Young People's Mental Health Services)

Don't Isolate Them by Default

Safety measures can cut a young person off from the friends who support them. Ask them **where they feel safe, who they trust, and who they want around them**, and build the plan with them. Friends are often the first people a young person tells, and can be their safety net. Avoid plans that put the whole burden on the victim to "keep away" or "make better choices".

Firmin et al., *Beyond Risk in Adolescent Safeguarding* (2026), pp. 88, 119 to 120 and 145 to 146.

Support for Witnesses

Witnesses May Also Be Affected

- Acknowledge what they observed/experienced
- Reinforce that speaking up was the right thing to do
- Address any fears about retaliation

- Provide education about allyship and bystander intervention
- Monitor their wellbeing (witnessing can be traumatic)
- Affirm their role in creating safer school culture

Support for Student Displaying Behaviour (Separate Context)

Accountability and Support for the Alleged Perpetrator

- **Address behaviour without attacking personhood:** Focus on actions, not identity
- **Explore influences and belief systems (DSL-led, after any disclosure has been passed on):** Where are these attitudes coming from? Staff who receive a disclosure must not confront or question the alleged perpetrator
- **Provide education:** Healthy relationships, consent, respect, gender equality
- **Targeted interventions:** *Freedom from violence and abuse* commits to piloting school-based interventions for young people displaying harmful behaviours, including teenage relationship abuse, from September 2026. Check local availability with the DSL
- **Connect with interventions:** Counselling, mentoring, healthy relationships programmes. Frame this work without stigmatising boys
- **Clear consequences:** Under the behaviour policy, with education on the harm caused
- **Understand impact of actions:** Real consequences on victims/survivors
- **Monitoring and follow-up:** Ensure behaviour change sustained

Family Engagement

Working with Parents/Carers

- Parent/carer notification decided by the DSL (not where it would put the child at greater risk)
- Family support resources provided, including the Parent Guide 101 - Ages 4 to 18
- Cultural sensitivity in communication (use interpreters if needed)
- Transparent about actions taken
- Partnership in safety planning
- Frame within universal values: dignity, safety, respect
- Explain UK legal obligations clearly

Specialist Services

External Support Referral Pathways

- **SARC (Sexual Assault Referral Centres):** Medical examination, evidence collection, crisis support
- **Rape Crisis England & Wales:** 24/7 Rape and Sexual Abuse Support Line, ages 16+ (0808 500 2222)
- **Domestic abuse support:** If relevant to home situation
- **Children and Young People's Mental Health Services:** referral for trauma-focused therapy, via the DSL and the school nurse or health centre
- **Local authority VAWG services:** Specialist gender-based violence support
- **Childline:** 24/7 confidential support (0800 1111)
- **The Mix:** Online support for under-25s (themix.org.uk; check current contact options)
- **Galop:** LGBT+ young people aged 13 to 25 use the Children and Young People's Service (under-18s: online referral form at galop.org.uk/make-a-referral, or Childline); the National LGBT+ Domestic Abuse Helpline (0800 999 5428) is for people aged 18 and over
- **Report Remove (Childline and IWF):** Helps under-18s get nude images of themselves removed from the internet

Staff Self-Regulation

Looking After Yourself

RESPOND Staff Wellbeing Micro-Protocol: a **10-second reset** in the moment, a **2-minute debrief** with a colleague or the DSL afterwards, and **know your boundary**. A dysregulated adult cannot regulate a dysregulated child.

- Recognise your own emotional responses (anger, frustration, disbelief)
- Maintain professional composure to support students effectively
- Acknowledge this is challenging content requiring collective response
- Access peer support and supervision as needed
- Debrief with DSL or senior colleague
- Process emotional impact in appropriate setting
- Use the school's Employee Assistance Programme if it has one, or Education Support: free, confidential, 24/7 on 08000 562 561

Boarding-Specific Considerations

24/7 Residential Support

- Ensure boarding house is safe environment
- Consider room changes if necessary for safety; the alleged perpetrator should move, not the victim, unless the victim asks otherwise
- House staff briefing on monitoring and support
- Weekend/evening check-ins scheduled
- Peer support structures activated
- On-call staff informed and available
- Monitoring of social dynamics in residential setting
- See **Boarding and Residential Life** for out-of-hours response, house culture, devices and international families



PAUSE: Consider Your Approach

Act with composure. The Pause creates space for professional judgement: it's not delay, it's deliberate thinking.

90-Second Grounding, Then the Three Lenses

Breathe, lower your shoulders and check your own state. Then look through the Three Lenses:

- **Risk: What is the level of danger?** Threats, images, a group, an older student, a pattern, online or off-site elements
- **Rights: What does this child need?** Safety, to be believed, a say in what happens, dignity and privacy
- **Resources: Who else needs to know?** The DSL first; then, through the DSL, the school nurse or health centre, online safety, boarding or pastoral staff

Check for bias and counter-transference: are your own experiences or assumptions shaping how you see this?

Critical: What NOT to Do

- **Do NOT** interrogate students about details

- **Do NOT** search students' phones yourself (senior staff act under the DfE *Searching, screening and confiscation* guidance)
- **Do NOT** contact parents before DSL consultation
- **Do NOT** attempt to mediate between students
- **Do NOT** promise confidentiality to anyone involved
- **Do NOT** collect physical evidence yourself (leave for police)
- **Do NOT** view, copy, screenshot or forward nude or semi-nude images, including AI-generated ones (note location only)

Consider Systemic Context

Cultural and Institutional Factors

- **Individual vs. Cultural:** Is this individual behaviour or broader cultural issue in school?
- **Institutional Enabling:** Are there institutional factors enabling this behaviour?
- **Normalisation:** How has school culture normalised certain attitudes?
- **Prevention:** What preventative measures need strengthening?
- **Staff Response:** Have similar concerns been minimised before?
- **Gender Imbalances:** How do power dynamics manifest in this setting?

Cultural Humility (Without Excusing Harm)

- Recognise your own cultural assumptions about gender
- Understand student may come from culture with different norms
- Balance cultural sensitivity with child protection obligations
- Consider how to engage families constructively
- Acknowledge complexity without compromising safeguarding
- Cultural attitudes to gender may be in play, but UK law applies to all
- Family honour/shame considerations may complicate disclosure
- Faith community involvement may be helpful or harmful

Intersectionality Awareness

- **Multiple Identities:** How does this interact with race, disability, sexual orientation, faith, or a student questioning their gender?
- **Targeted Groups:** Are certain groups of girls more targeted?
- **Compounding Effects:** Consider compounding effects of multiple marginalised identities
- **Complex Experience:** Ensure support addresses full complexity of student's experience
- **International Students:** Specific vulnerabilities for EAL/international students
- **Lesbian, Gay, Bisexual and Gender-Questioning Students:** May face combined sexist and homophobic harassment, or harassment for not conforming to expectations of their sex, and may be less likely to report
- **So-Called Honour-Based Abuse and Forced Marriage:** Be alert where control is linked to family or community reputation

Power Dynamics

- Recognise gender power imbalances in school and society
- Consider how gendered power operates in this setting
- Acknowledge resistance to change from those benefiting from status quo
- Understand this is not just about individual behaviour but systemic issues
- Age or physical power imbalance between students?
- Social status differential impacting dynamic?
- Group dynamics reinforcing harmful attitudes?

Manosphere Content

Ask what the content gives the student (belonging, certainty, aspiration, emotion, authenticity) before deciding what to do. One phrase is not a diagnosis; use the Three Lenses on the pattern. See **Staff Guide 102: Online Influence and the Manosphere**.

Bias Check

Critical Self-Reflection Questions

- **Am I minimising this because it's normalised?** (Check for "banter" acceptance)

- **Am I blaming the targeted student (victim-blaming)?** ("What was she wearing/doing?")
- **Am I assuming "boys will be boys"?** (Excusing behaviour based on gender)
- **Am I dismissing online harassment as "not real"?** (Digital harm is real harm)
- **Am I making assumptions about "types" of victims/survivors?** (Anyone can experience VAWG)
- **Am I excusing the alleged perpetrator's behaviour?** (Cultural background, peer pressure, etc.)
- **Am I considering intersectionality?** (Multiple identity factors)
- **Am I applying VAWG lens appropriately?** (Gender-based violence framework)

Risk Assessment Questions

Immediate Risk Factors

- Is victim at immediate risk of harm?
- Is the alleged perpetrator a risk to others?
- Are there multiple victims?
- Is this part of broader pattern?
- Is organised abuse involved?
- Are there extra-familial factors (community violence, gang involvement)?

Legal Considerations

- Could a criminal offence have been committed? (The DSL and police decide this, not the member of staff)
- Age and capacity factors relevant?
- Are consent frameworks applicable?
- Is police involvement required?
- Does LADO need notification (if staff involved)?
- Is evidence preservation required?

Trauma-Informed Questions

- How to avoid re-traumatisation?
- What does victim/survivor want/need now?
- How to maintain victim/survivor agency?
- What supports victim/survivor resilience?
- How to prevent secondary victimisation through response process?

Multi-Agency Coordination

- Who needs to be involved?
- What's the threshold for each agency?
- How to coordinate without duplication?
- What's the safeguarding partnership role?
- How to share information appropriately?



OFFER: Model Alternatives

Explain what happens next, and model the alternative. Never promise confidentiality, specific outcomes, or that nothing will change.

If in Doubt, N before O

When you are unsure, **Notify the DSL before Offering** any options. For the student who has been harmed, explain honestly what happens next. For the student who caused harm, model the alternative: the education, consequences and support below are arranged by the DSL and pastoral team, not decided on the spot.

For Student Displaying Misogynistic Behaviour

Educational Interventions

- **Critical media literacy:** Deconstruct harmful online content (misogynistic influencers, incel culture, the manosphere)
- **Healthy masculinity exploration:** Positive role models and alternative ways of being a young man
- **Consent and respect education:** Understanding boundaries, autonomy, enthusiastic agreement
- **Empathy development:** Perspective-taking exercises - understand impact on victims/survivors
- **Gender equality curriculum:** Historical and contemporary context, women's rights
- **VAWG awareness education:** Understanding violence against women and girls
- **Impact understanding:** Real consequences of actions on targeted students

Behavioural Alternatives

Reframe harmful behaviours:

"Instead of rating women, focus on valuing people's full humanity."

"Instead of dominating conversations, practise active listening."

"Instead of policing women's appearance, respect their autonomy."

"Instead of sharing misogynistic content, challenge it."

"Instead of objectifying, recognise women as complete human beings."

Restorative Approaches

Safeguards

- Restorative work is **not automatic** and follows the DSL's risk assessment
- The harmed child must **never be pressured** into contact, apology meetings or reconciliation, and can decline at any point

- It **does not replace** safeguarding, disciplinary or police action
- Generally not appropriate for sexual violence or where there is a significant power imbalance

- Understand harm caused to targeted students
- Take accountability for impact (not just intent)
- Make amends through changed behaviour
- Contribute to safer school culture
- Restorative processes: DSL-led only, with the victim's informed agreement; generally not appropriate for sexual violence or where there is a significant power imbalance
- Behaviour change programmes (including the Government's school-based pilot for young people displaying harmful behaviours, from September 2026)

For Targeted Student (Empowerment)

Empowerment Strategies

- ✓ **Rights education:** Understanding legal protections and school policies
- ✓ **Assertiveness skills:** Safely setting boundaries (when appropriate and safe)
- ✓ **Support networks:** Connecting with peers and trusted adults
- ✓ **Reporting mechanisms:** Clear, confidential pathways to report concerns
- ✓ **Agency restoration:** Choices in how to proceed and what support to access
- ✓ **Safety planning ownership:** Voice in process respected
- ✓ **Strengths-based framing:** Focus on resilience and capabilities
- ✓ **Advocacy support available:** Help navigating systems

Therapeutic Interventions

- Trauma-focused therapy (via Children and Young People's Mental Health Services)
- Group support programmes (with specialist providers)
- Peer support networks (where safe and supervised)
- Creative/expressive therapies
- Resilience building programmes
- Self-esteem work

Share with the Student

After the conversation, point students to the self-guided RESPOND student guides: the Student Guide 101 - 11 to 14 and Student Guide 101 - 14 to 18. They cover what misogyny looks like, how it affects boys and girls, what to do if it happens, and who can help. Share the guide, not this staff page. For families, share the Parent Guide 101 - Ages 4 to 18.

For School Community (Whole-School Approaches)

Prevention Education (RSHE and Wider Curriculum)

The revised RSHE statutory guidance (July 2025, which schools must follow from September 2026) strengthens teaching on misogyny, incel culture and their influence on attitudes towards women and girls, pornography, AI and deepfake images. A whole-school prevention offer typically includes:

- Healthy relationships (characteristics, warning signs)
- Consent
- Misogyny and incel culture, and how they negatively affect boys and young men as well as girls
- Gender equality principles and history
- Safe bystander intervention using RESPOND's 4Ds (Direct, Distract, Delegate, Delay), stressing that direct challenge is only one option and only when it is safe
- Critical media literacy (deconstructing harmful content)
- Pornography impact education
- Digital safety and respect
- Understanding VAWG - recognising and responding

Government Commitments:

Freedom from violence and abuse (December 2025)

£3 million teacher training fund over two years, and £5 million to pilot healthy relationships training delivered by external providers. The strategy states that by the end of this Parliament (2029), "every secondary school in England will have a credible offer for educating students about healthy and respectful relationships, with every child able to access support". Independent schools should plan on that basis.

Cultural Change Initiatives

- ✓ Zero-tolerance policies enforced consistently
- ✓ Positive masculinity programmes (alternative narratives for boys, without stigmatising them)
- ✓ Female leadership visibility (role models and representation)
- ✓ Gender equality campaigns (student-led and staff-supported)
- ✓ Student-led initiatives supported and resourced
- ✓ Staff modelling respect in all interactions
- ✓ Challenge "banter" culture systematically
- ✓ Celebrate equality achievements and milestones

Environmental Modifications

- ✓ Safe space creation (designated quiet/support areas)
- ✓ Supervision in risk areas (corridors, bathrooms, remote areas)
- ✓ Inclusive, non-stereotyped language in communications
- ✓ Diverse representation in materials (posters, curriculum examples)
- ✓ Reporting mechanisms visible and accessible
- ✓ Single-sex spaces where needed for safety
- ✓ Staff presence in corridors during transitions
- ✓ Online monitoring enhanced for digital VAWG

Subject-Specific Integration

- **English:** Analysing representation of women in literature, challenging stereotypes
- **History:** Women's rights movements and gender equality progress
- **Science:** Challenging stereotypes about ability and aptitude by sex
- **Computing:** Digital citizenship and online harassment
- **PE:** Challenging gender stereotypes in sport
- **Art/Drama:** Exploring identity, power, and representation

Policy Review and Development

- ✓ Anti-harassment and anti-bullying (VAWG-specific section)
Equality and diversity policy updated

- ✓ Online safety and acceptable use policies
- ✓ Reporting and whistleblowing procedures clear
- ✓ Sanctions and restorative approaches balanced
- ✓ Staff code of conduct includes VAWG prevention

Parent, Carer and Guardian Education

- Workshops on healthy relationships
- Online safety and digital VAWG awareness
- Understanding RSHE curriculum content
- Recognising warning signs at home
- Supporting children who experience or witness VAWG
- Challenging harmful attitudes in family context

N

NOTIFY: Report the Issue

Share concerns with the right people. Your duty is to pass on, not to investigate. You don't need certainty: you need to share your concern. Inform the DSL so they can decide the proportionate next step. KCSIE expects a case-by-case response: some incidents need police, children's social care or SARC involvement; others can be managed within school with support and monitoring. The DSL weighs the child's wishes, ages and development, any power imbalance, whether there is a pattern, and wider risk.

When to Tell the DSL

KCSIE requires staff to act on concerns in line with the school's safeguarding policy and to speak to the DSL or a deputy. It does not set a national deadline. If the DSL or a deputy is unavailable and a child is at risk of immediate harm, call 999 or refer directly to children's social care.

RESPOND standard Tell the DSL **as soon as is practicably possible**, in person or by phone.

Where a child is at risk of immediate harm, there is a disclosure of sexual violence, or nudes or semi-nudes are involved, that means now: do not wait until the end of the lesson or the day. If a child is in immediate danger and the DSL team cannot be reached, call 999.

- ✓ Incidents of misogynistic behaviour or language (recorded on the school's safeguarding system)

- ✓ Patterns of harassment or hostile environment
- ✓ Online misogyny involving students
- ✓ Any intersection with sexual harassment or violence
- ✓ Any concern that a student may be being drawn into terrorism or supporting terrorist violence (the DSL decides whether Prevent applies)
- ✓ Reports from multiple sources about same individual/group
- ✓ Any VAWG indicator observed or disclosed

Sharing Information: the Statutory Duty (from 30 September 2026)

In school, concerns go to the DSL, who leads on sharing with other agencies. Under the **Information Sharing Duty** (section 16LA of the Children Act 2004), information relevant to a child's safety or welfare **must** be shared with other safeguarding agencies where it may help them. There is no threshold to meet: this includes early help, unmet need and situations where a child may pose a risk to others.

The three questions the statutory guidance asks:

- **Is it relevant?** Does it bear on the child's safety or welfare? This can include information about another child or adult connected to them.
- **Could it help?** Could it help the other agency assess need, make a decision, provide support or take action?
- **Would sharing do more harm than not sharing?** This is rare: for example, where sharing would put the child at immediate risk or prejudice a police investigation. Lack of consent, a parent's objection, fear of complaint, feeling unsure, or data protection are **not** reasons not to share. If you are unsure, ask the DSL (or the Data Protection Officer on data protection) straight away.

How to share well:

- **Share what is relevant and necessary:** a summary rather than a whole file, and no stigmatising labels or untested allegations unless they are relevant.
- **Check your assumptions:** would the same information about a different child be seen in the same way?
- **Be open with the young person and family,** unless that would increase the risk: explain what will be shared, with whom and why. Don't ask permission if the information will be shared anyway; that offers a false choice. Acknowledge their worries, and keep their wishes and feelings in view.
- **Record the decision** to share, or not to share, and the reasons.

Information Sharing Duty statutory guidance (September 2026), paragraphs 11 to 14, 18, 21, 33 and 42 to 45. Research supports being open: fear of privacy breaches is one of the main reasons young people do not tell professionals what is happening to them (Firmin et al., *Beyond Risk in Adolescent Safeguarding* (2026), p. 58).

Information to Provide DSL

Context First: where harm is happening outside the family (peer groups, group chats, transport, the community), tell the DSL about the context as well as the individual, using the 4 Ps, so the response can address the places and groups involved and not only the child.

- ✓ **Incident details:** What, when, where, who
- ✓ **Direct quotes:** Exact language used (verbatim)
- ✓ **Pattern information:** First time or ongoing issue?
- ✓ **Digital evidence location:** Note platform, account, date and time. Say whether images are involved
- ✓ **Impact assessment:** Effect on targeted student(s)
- ✓ **Immediate actions taken:** Support provided
- ✓ **Witnesses:** Who else observed/aware
- ✓ **VAWG context:** Gender-based violence indicators

▼ For the DSL: working with other agencies, and legal considerations

Most staff need only: tell the DSL, today, with the information above.

DSL Coordination With

Internal Coordination

- **Senior Leadership:** Whole-school culture review, policy implications
- **Pastoral Team:** Individual student support plans
- **IT Services:** Digital evidence preservation (if relevant)
- **Online Safety Lead:** Digital VAWG component
- **Senior Mental Health Lead:** Trauma support coordination
- **SENCO:** If vulnerable student involved
- **Boarding Staff:** If residential student (24/7 monitoring)

External Agencies

Police (DSL decision, same day where required):

- Threats of violence or sexual violence

- Nudes or semi-nudes where UKCIS criteria for police referral are met: an adult is involved; coercion, blackmail or grooming; concerns about capacity to consent; images showing acts atypical for the child's development or violent acts; a child under 13; or immediate risk of harm
- Stalking or persistent harassment
- Harassment or threats motivated by hostility towards women and girls
- Evidence of adult grooming/exploitation
- Serious sexual assault

Children's Social Care or Targeted Early Help (Family Help) (same day where threshold is met):

- Significant harm or risk of significant harm
- Child protection concerns
- Family factors contributing to vulnerability

SARC (Sexual Assault Referral Centre):

- Sexual assault or violence
- Medical examination needed
- Evidence collection required
- Crisis support for victims/survivors

Prevent (DSL decision, only where the threshold is met):

- Prevent is for concerns that someone may be being radicalised into terrorism or supporting terrorist violence
- Misogynistic views, influencer content or incel material are **not automatically** a Prevent concern. Most cases are handled through safeguarding, behaviour and education responses
- Staff follow **Notice, Check, Share**: notice the concern, check it with the DSL, and the DSL shares with Prevent if the threshold is met
- Indicators that may meet it: expressing support for or glorifying attacks, intent or planning to harm others, or active engagement with violent extremist networks

Local Authority VAWG Lead:

- Strategic coordination
- Specialist VAWG services access
- Multi-agency support

Family Notification

Parents, carers and, for international boarders, educational guardians (age-appropriate notification):

- The DSL decides when and how parents are informed: usually promptly, unless this would put the child at greater risk
- Cultural sensitivity in communication
- Use interpreters if needed
- Frame within universal values (dignity, safety, respect)
- Explain UK legal framework clearly
- Offer support resources for family

When NOT to Notify Parents Immediately

- Risk of so-called honour-based abuse
- Forced marriage concerns
- Family violence suspected
- Student at risk from family
- Police investigation would be compromised

Consult DSL/Children's Social Care before notifying in these situations.

Legal Considerations

Statutory Framework

- **KCSIE 2026:** Child-on-child abuse (including harassment and violence); added references to misogyny and VAWG; zero tolerance of sexual harassment and sexual violence; all staff act on concerns and speak to the DSL
- **Working Together to Safeguard Children 2026:** Multi-agency arrangements, including Family Help
- **Freedom from violence and abuse (December 2025):** Cross-government VAWG strategy; schools central to prevention
- **Equality Act 2010 (Part 6):** Schools must not discriminate against or harass students because of sex. A school's response to sex-based harassment between students must itself be non-discriminatory; take legal advice on specific cases

- **Equality Act 2010 (as amended by the Worker Protection Act 2023 and the Employment Rights Act 2025):** Employers must take reasonable steps to prevent sexual harassment of staff; from 30 October 2026 this becomes **all reasonable steps**, and employers must not permit harassment of staff by third parties, which in a school includes students and parents
- **Public Sector Equality Duty (s149):** Applies to state-funded schools; independent schools are not bound by it
- **RSHE statutory guidance (July 2025, in force September 2026):** Teaching on consent, healthy relationships, misogyny and incel culture
- **Anti-bullying duty:** Independent School Standards, Part 3, paragraph 10 (an effective anti-bullying strategy, implemented so far as reasonably practicable; DfE guidance expects it to address cyberbullying and prejudice-based bullying); maintained schools: Education and Inspections Act 2006, section 89

Potential Criminal Offences

England and Wales. This list helps staff recognise when police involvement may be needed. Staff do not decide whether an offence has been committed. KCSIE is clear that the law is in place to protect children rather than criminalise them.

Harassment and Stalking:

- Protection from Harassment Act 1997 (including stalking offences, sections 2A and 4A)
- Stalking Protection Act 2019 (Stalking Protection Orders)

Communications Offences:

- Online Safety Act 2023 offences: threatening communications, false communications and cyberflashing. These replaced parts of the older regime
- Remaining provisions of the Malicious Communications Act 1988 and Communications Act 2003, section 127 (grossly offensive, indecent or obscene messages), as amended by the Online Safety Act 2023

Sexual Offences:

- Sexual Offences Act 2003 (including sharing or threatening to share intimate images, inserted by the Online Safety Act 2023)
- Voyeurism (Offences) Act 2019 (upskirting)
- Protection of Children Act 1978 and Criminal Justice Act 1988, section 160 (the offences behind what KCSIE 2026 calls making or sharing nudes or semi-nudes of under-18s, including AI-generated or altered images)

Key Contact Numbers

National VAWG Support Services

- **Police:** 999 (emergency), 101 (non-emergency)
- **Rape Crisis England & Wales (24/7, ages 16+):** 0808 500 2222
- **National Domestic Abuse Helpline (24/7):** 0808 2000 247
- **Childline:** 0800 1111 (24/7 confidential support)
- **The Mix (under-25s):** online support at themix.org.uk
- **Galop (LGBT+ domestic abuse):** helpline 0800 999 5428 for people aged 18 and over; under-18s use Galop's young people's referral form (galop.org.uk/make-a-referral) or Childline
- **Karma Nirvana (so-called honour-based abuse and forced marriage):** 0800 5999 247
- **NSPCC Helpline (adults worried about a child):** 0808 800 5000, 10am to 4pm, Monday to Friday

National numbers checked September 2026. Verify at point of use.

Your School and Local Contacts

Add your own school's details here, or keep them to hand. Names and numbers are in your school's child protection and safeguarding policy.

In school

- **Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL) and deputies (DDSLs):** named in the safeguarding policy, including the boarding DDSL and out-of-hours on-call arrangements where the school has boarders
- **School nurse or health centre:** for medical support for students
- **Prevent lead:** usually the DSL

Local authority and partners

- **Children's services front door** (the single point of access or MASH): referrals and advice, including the consultation line for the DSL team
- **Out-of-hours emergency duty team:** evenings, weekends and bank holidays
- **Local Authority Designated Officer (LADO):** concerns about the conduct of staff, volunteers or contractors
- **Local safeguarding children partnership:** multi-agency procedures and the local threshold or continuum of support document

- **Local domestic abuse service:** find it through the local authority website or the National Domestic Abuse Helpline, 0808 2000 247
- **Police:** 999 if urgent, 101 for advice

Prevent and specialist services

- **Prevent concerns:** the DSL first; the DfE Prevent Helpline, 0800 011 3764; local police via 101
- **Sexual Assault Referral Centre (SARC):** find the nearest with the NHS SARC finder. The DSL, with police where involved, arranges referral for a student
- **Stop It Now (Lucy Faithfull Foundation):** 0808 1000 900, Monday to Thursday 9am to 9pm, Friday 9am to 5pm, confidential advice for anyone concerned about child sexual abuse, including harmful sexual behaviour by young people

National numbers checked September 2026. Verify at point of use.

D

DOCUMENT: Record Observations

Record factually, as soon as is practicably possible after the event, using your reporting system. If it's not written down, it didn't happen. Your record may be used in criminal proceedings.

G: Ground

Date, time, location, who you are and who was present

O: Observe

What you saw and heard, with the child's exact words in quotation marks

L: Language

Neutral, factual and non-diagnostic: no opinions or labels

D: Do

The actions you took and why

Incident Record (Immediate Documentation)

Essential Information to Record (GOLD Template)

Date: [DD/MM/YYYY]

Time: [HH:MM]

Location: [Specific location]

Staff Member: [Your name and role]

STUDENTS INVOLVED:

Targeted Student(s): [Names, ages, year groups]

Student(s) Displaying Behaviour: [Names, ages, year groups]

Witnesses: [Names]

INCIDENT DESCRIPTION:

[Factual account of what occurred - who, what, when, where]

[Chronological sequence of events]

[Observable behaviours and actions]

EXACT WORDS USED:

"[Quote misogynistic language/statements verbatim]"

"[Direct quotes from all parties - use quotation marks]"

OBSERVED IMPACT:

[How targeted student responded]

[Emotional state observed]

[Physical reactions]

[Immediate wellbeing concerns]

VAWG CONTEXT:

[Gender-based nature of incident]

[Pattern of behaviour if known]

[Power dynamics observed]

[Intersectionality factors]

[Online/offline components]

IMMEDIATE ACTIONS TAKEN:

[What you did immediately]

[Support provided to victim/survivor]

[Action taken with the student displaying the behaviour]

[Safety measures implemented]

REPORTED TO:

DSL Name: [Name]

Time Reported: [HH:MM]

Method: [In person/phone/email]

FOLLOW-UP REQUIRED:

[Note any ongoing concerns or additional actions needed]

The Read-Back Test

- **Would the young person feel cared about if they read this record?** GOLD asks for neutral, factual language: avoid distancing labels such as "unpleasant", "lifestyle choice" or "not engaging".
- **Record strengths, not only risks:** friendships, loyalty, trusted adults, interests, what is going well.
- **Close with what we will do**, not only what more we need to know.
- Reluctance to share is often a reasonable response to past experience, not "non-engagement". Record what would help them feel safe to talk.

Drawn from Firmin et al., *Beyond Risk in Adolescent Safeguarding* (2026), pp. 26, 37 to 38, 66 to 67 and 106.

Pattern Documentation (If Ongoing)

- ✓ Create timeline of incidents (dates, brief descriptions)
- ✓ Note who is involved and how they are connected, including friends and trusted people who could be a source of support, not only risk
- ✓ Track locations and contexts where behaviour occurs
- ✓ Note any escalation or changes in severity
- ✓ Identify systemic factors enabling behaviour
- ✓ Document group dynamics and peer influences

Digital Evidence (If Relevant)

CRITICAL: Evidence Preservation Rules

Nude or semi-nude images of anyone under 18 (including AI-generated or altered images): never view, copy, screenshot, save or forward them. Follow UKCIS guidance and the DSL's direction; the DSL may arrange for devices to be secured.

Other online harassment (messages, posts, comments without intimate images): preservation may be needed. Ask the DSL before capturing anything, and follow their direction on how it is recorded and stored.

- **DO** note exact location of content (platform, group name, date/time)
- **DO** note device/platform information
- **DO** preserve device security (don't delete anything)

- **DO** report to DSL who will coordinate with IT/Police for proper preservation
- **DO** document who has seen the content

Debrief Requirements

Personal Reflection

- How did this incident affect you emotionally?
- What biases or assumptions did you notice in your response?
- What would you do differently?
- What support do you need?
- Did you maintain trauma-informed approach?
- Were you able to avoid victim-blaming language?

Professional Supervision

- Discuss case with DSL or senior colleague
- Process emotional impact and complexity
- Identify learning and development needs
- Plan ongoing monitoring and support
- Review adherence to RESPOND protocol
- Consider need for external supervision or counselling

Institutional Learning

- What does this reveal about school culture?
- What preventative measures need strengthening?
- How can curriculum address misogyny more effectively?
- What staff training gaps exist?
- Are policies adequate and implemented consistently?
- How can we better support targeted students?
- What systemic changes are needed?

VAWG-Specific Terminology

Use Clear, Accurate Terms

- **Sexual harassment** (not "inappropriate behaviour")
- **Sexual assault**, where the conduct has been appropriately identified; otherwise describe the behaviour factually and use the child's own words
- **Misogyny** (not "rudeness")
- **Gender-based violence** (not "conflict")
- **Victim**, or the term the child is comfortable with (some prefer "survivor", some neither)
- **Alleged perpetrator** (KCSIE term until facts are established; with children, "the student who displayed the behaviour")
- **VAWG** (Violence Against Women and Girls)

Avoid Minimising Language

- ❌ "Banter"
- ❌ "Joke that went wrong"
- ❌ "Misunderstanding"
- ❌ "Relationship issue"
- ❌ "Both sides"
- ❌ "Drama"
- ❌ "Inappropriate behaviour" (when it's assault/harassment)

Confidentiality Note

Information Sharing Protocol

This record contains sensitive safeguarding information related to Violence Against Women and Girls (VAWG).

Sharing is restricted to those with legitimate safeguarding need in accordance with:

- KCSIE 2026

- Working Together to Safeguard Children 2026
- Local safeguarding partnership protocols
- UK GDPR and Data Protection Act 2018, as amended by the Data (Use and Access) Act 2025
- Information Sharing Duty under section 16LA of the Children Act 2004, inserted by the Children's Wellbeing and Schools Act 2026 (in force from 30 September 2026), and the associated statutory guidance, *Information Sharing Duty: statutory guidance for safeguarding organisations and their practitioners* (September 2026)

Multi-agency information sharing must be:

- Necessary and proportionate
- Relevant and adequate
- Accurate and up to date
- Secure
- Documented (who, what, why, when)

When the Target Is a Member of Staff

Misogyny in schools is not only directed at students. Female teachers and support staff are also targeted by students, online and in person. This section applies RESPOND when the person harmed is an adult in the school.

Two Routes, Running Together

- **The student's behaviour** is a behaviour and, where indicated, a safeguarding matter. It is recorded on the school's system and the DSL considers what it says about the student and the wider culture.
- **The harm to the member of staff** is a staff wellbeing and employment matter. Her line manager and HR are responsible for her support and for the school's duties as employer.

One route does not replace the other. A member of staff should never be left to manage the consequences alone because the student is "just a child", and a student's safeguarding needs are not set aside because the victim is an adult.

The School's Duty as Employer

Since 26 October 2024 the Equality Act 2010, as amended by the Worker Protection (Amendment of Equality Act 2010) Act 2023, has required employers to take **reasonable steps**

to prevent sexual harassment of their employees, anticipating the risk before it happens.

From 30 October 2026 the Employment Rights Act 2025 strengthens this:

- Employers must take **all reasonable steps** to prevent sexual harassment
- Employers must not permit harassment of their employees by **third parties**. In a school, third parties include students, parents and visitors. The school can be liable for such harassment unless it has taken all reasonable steps to prevent it

This is a proactive duty on the school: risk assessment, clear policy, training and a consistent leadership response. It is not something an individual teacher is expected to secure for herself. Take HR or legal advice on individual cases.

R: Recognise

What It Can Look Like

- Sexualised or degrading comments about a teacher's body, clothing or private life
- Challenges to authority framed by sex: "I don't take orders from a woman", refusing instructions from female staff but not male staff
- "Rating" staff, noises, gestures, or comments made just loud enough to be heard
- Misogynistic influencer phrases directed at staff, or content shared in class to provoke
- Group behaviour: a class or friendship group coordinating disruption against one female teacher
- Online: fake accounts, posts, memes or group-chat content about a member of staff
- Covert photos or videos of staff, and **AI-altered or "deepfake" sexual images** of staff
- Harassment from parents, or from colleagues (see Notify below: this follows a different route)

Why It Is Often Missed

- Staff feel reporting it will look like they cannot manage their classes
- Comments are dismissed as "testing boundaries" or treated as low-level disruption
- Each incident seems too small to report, so the pattern is never seen
- Early career, supply, support and international staff may be targeted more and report less

Being targeted is not a sign of weak classroom management. Leaders should say this explicitly. Nearly a quarter (23.4%) of female teachers reported misogyny from a pupil in the last year, up from 17.4% in 2023 (NASUWT survey of over 5,000 teachers, 2026). Teachers report

misogynistic comments after addressing behaviour, and being ignored by male pupils because they are female.

E: Engage

In the Moment (If You Are the Target)

- If it is safe to do so, name it briefly and calmly: "That comment is sexist and it is not acceptable. We'll deal with it after the lesson."
- If you feel unsafe or the situation is escalating, do not challenge further: use the on-call system and get support
- Don't debate it in front of the class
- Use the on-call or removal system if the lesson cannot continue safely
- Note the exact words as soon as you can
- You do not have to deal with the follow-up yourself

If You Are a Colleague Who Witnesses It

- Don't leave it for her to challenge: if it is safe to do so, step in and name it; if not, get help
- Don't laugh along or let it pass as a joke
- Don't take over in a way that undermines her authority; support, then check in privately
- Report what you saw: a witness account strengthens the record
- **Male colleagues** challenging sexist behaviour towards female colleagues sends a clear message to students

S: Support

What the School Should Offer

- ✓ A same-day check-in from her line manager or a senior colleague of her choosing
- ✓ The option not to be the person who leads the follow-up with the student
- ✓ A say in whether and how any restorative conversation happens; it is never required of her

- ✓ Class, timetable or duty adjustments where the behaviour continues, falling on the student rather than on her
- ✓ A named senior leader to escalate to if the behaviour continues
- ✓ Access to the school's Employee Assistance Programme where there is one, Education Support (24/7 on 08000 562 561), and occupational health where relevant
- ✓ Reassurance that reporting will not be treated as a performance issue

External Support for Staff

- **Education Support (24/7, for education staff):** 08000 562 561
- **Professionals Online Safety Helpline (UK Safer Internet Centre):**
helpline@saferinternet.org.uk, Monday to Friday, for help with removing online content about staff
- **Revenge Porn Helpline (adults):** 0345 6000 459, 10am to 4pm, Monday to Friday, for intimate images shared or threatened without consent
- **Trade union:** advice and representation
- **Rape Crisis England & Wales (24/7):** 0808 500 2222

Numbers checked September 2026. Verify at point of use.

P: Pause

- **Is this one incident or a pattern?** Check whether other female staff have reported the same student or group.
- **What is driving it?** The student is still a child. Online influence, home, peer pressure or their own experience of harm may sit behind the behaviour, and the DSL should consider this.
- **Is there a risk to her safety?** Threats, following, or knowledge of her home or personal accounts raise the level of response.
- **Regulate before responding.** Being targeted is personal. It is reasonable to step back before deciding what to do next.

Do Not

- Search a student's phone yourself. Senior leaders act under the DfE *Searching, screening and confiscation* guidance
- View, copy or forward intimate or sexual images of the member of staff (including altered or deepfake images); note where they are and report. For other online content about her, agree with a senior leader how evidence is preserved
- Contact the student's parents yourself before agreeing the approach with a senior leader

- Respond to the content online

O: Offer

- **For the student:** a clear consequence under the behaviour policy, plus education on the impact of misogyny. Consequence and education sit together, not as alternatives.
- **For the member of staff:** choices about her involvement, a follow-up review date, and a clear outcome communicated to her.
- **For the class or year group:** where behaviour is collective, a planned response led by senior staff, not left to the targeted teacher.

N: Notify

Who to Tell, Depending on Who Is Responsible

A student:

- Record on the school's system as soon as is practicably possible and tell your line manager or head of year
- Tell the DSL where there are images, threats, sexual content, online abuse, a group dimension, or concerns about the student's own welfare
- Police via a senior leader where there are threats, stalking, or sharing or threatening to share intimate images (including altered images)

A parent or visitor:

- Senior leadership and HR; apply the school's policy on unacceptable behaviour by parents and visitors

A colleague:

- HR, under the dignity at work or grievance procedure
- If the behaviour also raises any concern about how that colleague behaves towards children, it is a safeguarding matter: follow KCSIE Part 4 (low-level concerns, or the headteacher and the Local Authority Designated Officer (LADO) where the harm threshold may be met)
- If the concern is about the headteacher, report to the chair of governors or proprietor

D: Document

- ✓ Date, time, location, exact words, and who was present

- ✓ Where online content is (platform, account, date) without copying images
- ✓ Action taken with the student, and the support offered to the member of staff
- ✓ The outcome communicated back to her
- ✓ Incidents against staff recorded in a way that lets leaders see patterns by sex, role and year group

For Leaders

- Review incidents against staff termly, alongside student incidents
- Include staff experience of misogyny in staff surveys
- Check the school's risk assessment and policies show **all reasonable steps** taken to prevent sexual harassment of staff, including by students and parents (the standard from 30 October 2026)
- A pattern of female staff being targeted is evidence about school culture, not about individual teachers

Boarding and Residential Life

For boarders, school is also home. There is no end of the day to go home to, harm can continue into evenings and weekends, and a student may be sleeping down the corridor from the person who harmed them.

What the Boarding Standards Ask For

National Minimum Standards for Boarding Schools (2026) (standard 8.4) asks boarding schools' safeguarding policies to reflect four risks, all relevant to misogyny:

- **Child-on-child abuse in shared overnight accommodation**, reflecting the unique nature of boarding
- **The school's policy on sexual relationships between children**, and that boarders understand it
- **Significant gender imbalance** in the school, a house or a year group
- **Devices and harmful online content**: devices brought in, content already downloaded, and 3G, 4G and 5G access that bypasses the school's filtering and monitoring

RESPOND in the Boarding House

Step	In boarding
● Recognise	Use the 4 Ps for the house: People (who shares rooms, tables, prep; older and younger boarders), Places (common rooms, corridors, bathrooms, bedrooms, the walk back from activities), Platforms (house group chats, phones after lights out), Patterns (evenings, weekends, exeats). Notice changes at meals, bedtime and sleep.
● Engage	Houseparents often hear things first, at informal times. Use that relationship: TED, not "why". If you witness something in a common room, use the 4Ds if it is safe to do so. Follow safer working practice: talk in a visible space with the door open, and let another adult know.
● Support	Safety tonight comes first: where will they sleep, who is on duty, and how do they reach night staff? Changes to rooms, tables, prep or trips should fall on the alleged perpetrator, not the victim, unless the victim asks otherwise. Don't isolate them from friends by default.
● Pause	Consider the whole house, not only the two students involved. Do not investigate or promise secrecy. If there is immediate risk, do not wait until morning.
● Offer	Model alternatives: house meetings on respect, older boarders and prefects as positive role models, and clear expectations for common rooms and chats. Restorative work only after the DSL's safeguarding decisions. If in doubt, N before O.
● Notify	Boarders can always reach their house parents, the DSL or the boarding management team. Out of hours, contact the on-call DSL or Boarding Deputy DSL straight away where there is risk (numbers under Key Contact Numbers). If a child is in immediate danger and no DSL can be reached, call 999; out of hours, contact the local authority's emergency duty team. The DSL decides how and when parents or guardians are told.
● Document	Record on the safeguarding system before you go off duty, using GOLD. A house log or handover note is not a substitute. Keep handover notes factual and share only what the next person needs.

Evenings, Weekends and Devices

- ✓ Much online content, including misogynistic and manosphere content, is watched in the evenings and at weekends. That is when boarding staff are the adults on hand.
- ✓ Mobile data can bypass school filtering, and content may already be on a device. Follow the school's arrangements for devices after lights out (for example, whether and when phones are collected from younger boarders, as set out in the online safety policy).
- ✓ Monitoring of boarders' communications should be proportionate (NMS 12.1), and must never stop private contact with parents or access to help.
- ✓ Nudes or semi-nudes: do not view, copy, forward or delete. Secure the device if needed and contact the DSL, following the UKCIS guidance.

House Culture

- **Common-room and dorm "banter":** sexist jokes, rating lists and group-chat talk that would be challenged in a classroom must be challenged in the house too.
- **Initiation and hierarchy:** the boarding standards require policies on countering initiation and hazing. Watch for older boarders pressuring younger ones, and for status games between year groups.
- **Older boarders and prefects** shape the culture. Brief them on expectations, and on passing concerns to staff rather than dealing with them alone.
- **Gender balance:** where one sex is in a small minority in a house, activity or year group, check how they experience it.

International Boarders and Families

- Parents may be many time zones away. Agree with the DSL who contacts them, when, and in what language; use interpreters where needed.
- Educational guardians may be the adults on hand in the UK. Be clear about what they are told and what they are not, in line with the guardianship agreement.
- Students may come from places with different norms about gender and relationships. Explain the school's expectations and the law in England respectfully and clearly; the standards apply to everyone.
- Some students will not want their parents told. Listen to why. The DSL decides, taking into account any risk that telling parents could create.
- Boarders must be able to contact their families in private at a suitable time (NMS 12.1).

When the Target Is a Houseparent

- Houseparents live on site, sometimes with their partners and children. Misogyny aimed at them comes home with them.
- They should not have to handle it alone or be the one to sanction it. A senior colleague leads the response, as set out in **When the Target Is a Member of Staff**.
- Consider the impact on staff households, and whether cover or a change of duty is needed while it is resolved.

Boarders' Routes to Help

- ✓ **Boarders can always contact their house parents, the DSL or a member of the boarding management team, at any time, day or night.** Make sure every boarder knows how, and that the on-call rota makes it possible.
- ✓ Any member of staff, and all staff know what to do if a boarder raises a concern (NMS 11.3)

- ✓ An **independent person** outside the staff whom boarders know and can contact directly (NMS 11.4; often called the independent listener)
- ✓ At least two child support services (NMS 11.5), for example **Childline** 0800 1111 and the Children's Commissioner's **Help at Hand** 0800 528 0731
- ✓ A way to reach a member of staff at night, which every boarder knows (NMS 20.8)
- ✓ Ways to raise concerns and give views without being penalised for doing so in good faith (NMS 13.1 and 14.2)

Sources: National Minimum Standards for Boarding Schools (2026); Department for Education, *Keeping Children Safe in Education 2026*; Children's Commissioner, Help at Hand; the school's online safety policy.

Online Influence and the Manosphere

Much of the misogyny students repeat now reaches them through short videos, memes, gaming and fitness content. The full guidance is in **Staff Guide 102: Online Influence and the Manosphere**: what the manosphere is, a glossary of terms staff may hear, how it presents at different ages, the NOISE critical-literacy check, a card sort, and three worked scenarios.

The Essentials

- **Track the message, not the name.** RESPOND names no influencers; the next one may be someone you have never heard of.
- **Recognise the pattern without labelling the child.** One phrase is not a diagnosis. Use the Three Lenses on the pattern.
- **Curiosity before confrontation.** Name the harm, ask one open question ("What does that mean to you?"), and don't argue about the influencer.
- **Ask what the content gives the student:** belonging, certainty, aspiration, emotion or authenticity.
- **Watch for harm to the boy himself:** fatalism, withdrawal, extreme dieting or talk of self-harm is a wellbeing concern first.
- Pass concerns to the DSL as soon as is practicably possible. Where content suggests extremist views, the DSL decides whether Prevent applies.

Open Staff Guide 102

Men and Boys: Responsibility and Role

Ending misogyny is not only a task for women and girls. Men and boys are part of the solution: as role models, as bystanders who act, and as people who can themselves be harmed.

Responsibility, Not Blame

KCSIE 2026 is clear that girls are more likely to be the victims of sexual harassment and sexual violence, and that it is more likely to be perpetrated by boys. The RSHE statutory guidance is equally clear that **most boys and young men are respectful** to girls, young women and each other, that anyone can be affected by sexual violence, and that staff should avoid language which suggests boys or men are always perpetrators. Students should have opportunities to identify and learn from **positive male role models**. Where misogynistic ideas are expressed, **challenge the ideas, not the person**.

Men on the Staff

- ✓ **Model it:** respectful language and conduct towards women and girls, in lessons, corridors, the staffroom and online
- ✓ **Don't leave it to women:** challenge sexist comments from students and colleagues yourself, if it is safe to do so. Silence can be read as agreement
- ✓ **Don't laugh along:** staffroom or sports-team "banter" sets the tone students copy
- ✓ **Back up female colleagues:** reinforce their authority rather than taking over; follow up privately to check they are OK
- ✓ **Take reports seriously:** listen, record and pass on to the DSL, in the same way as any other safeguarding concern
- ✓ **Reflect:** notice your own assumptions, for example who you ask to speak in class, whose behaviour you excuse, and how you describe girls and boys
- ✓ **Lead prevention:** volunteer to deliver or co-deliver healthy relationships work. Boys benefit from hearing it from men
- ✓ **Raise concerns about colleagues:** sexist conduct towards colleagues goes to HR. Any conduct that raises a concern about how a colleague behaves with students is reported under KCSIE Part 4, as a low-level concern or an allegation

What We Ask of Boys

Expectations

- Treat everyone with respect, in person and online
- Understand and respect consent
- Never make, share or forward sexual images, "rating" lists or rumours
- Think critically about online content that presents women as inferior or as owing men anything
- Be an upstander: if it is safe, say something; if not, tell a trusted adult afterwards
- Look out for friends who are being drawn into harmful content or behaviour

What We Offer Boys

- Positive male role models and space to talk about masculinity, pressure, friendship and loneliness
- Education that explains how misogyny harms boys and young men too
- Support when they are harmed: in the Ofsted review, 74% of boys said sexist name-calling and 40% said pressure to provide sexual images happens to them or their peers
- Help if they are worried about their own thoughts or behaviour: **Shore**, the Lucy Faithfull Foundation's anonymous service for teenagers (shorespace.org.uk)
- Consequences that are clear and fair, alongside education, so they can change
- Self-guided student guides written for boys and girls: the Student Guide 101 - 11 to 14 and Student Guide 101 - 14 to 18

Talking with Boys

Helpful

- "I'm not saying you're a bad person. I'm saying that comment causes harm."
- "Most boys here don't think like that. You can be one of the people who changes it."
- "What do you think it's like for her when that's said?"
- "Where did you come across that idea? Let's look at it together."

- "If you ever feel you can't say something in front of your mates, you can tell me afterwards."

Unhelpful

- "All men are..." or "Boys are the problem"
- Labels such as "toxic masculinity" aimed at an individual
- Treating every boy as a potential perpetrator
- Mocking the student, or naming specific influencers (the RSHE guidance advises against signposting content producers)
- Dismissing boys' own experiences of harassment or pressure

For Leaders

- ✓ Make sure men visibly lead and take part in prevention work, not only women
- ✓ Include male staff explicitly in expectations to challenge sexism among colleagues and students
- ✓ Give boys positive leadership roles in respect and wellbeing work, alongside girls
- ✓ Hear boys' voices in student surveys and act on what they say, including their own experiences of harm
- ✓ Check whether sanctions and support are applied consistently to boys and girls

Sources: Keeping Children Safe in Education 2026; Relationships Education, RSE and Health Education statutory guidance (July 2025), paragraphs 79 to 81; *Freedom from violence and abuse* action plan (December 2025), which commits to teaching about incels and misogynistic influencers "without stigmatising boys"; Ofsted, *Review of sexual abuse in schools and colleges* (June 2021).

Identity and Intersecting Harm

Misogyny rarely arrives alone. It is often combined with racism, religious hatred, disablism, homophobia or hostility towards gender-questioning students, and each makes the other worse. The response must not be diluted, and must not be applied unequally.

The Starting Point

KCSIE 2026 asks all staff to be aware that children with special educational needs and disabilities (SEND), children who are, or are perceived to be, lesbian, gay or bisexual, and

children who are questioning their gender may face additional vulnerability to bullying and abuse. It is clear that bullying, for whatever reason, is never acceptable (paras 249 to 259). Record every element of an incident: if it was sexist and racist, record both.

Race and Ethnicity

- **Sexualised racism:** slurs and "jokes" that combine race and sex, racialised stereotypes about girls' bodies or behaviour, and harassment of girls who wear religious dress such as the hijab.
- **Adultification:** Black girls in particular are more likely to be seen as older, more knowing and less in need of protection. Ask yourself whether you would see the same child as vulnerable if she were white.
- **Fairness in sanctions:** boys from some racially minoritised groups are more likely to be seen as a risk rather than at risk, and are over-represented in suspensions and exclusions. Check that responses to the same behaviour are consistent.
- **Online content** that mixes misogyny with racism or antisemitism needs the same challenge as content that is only misogynistic.

Firmin et al. (2026), pp. 9, 22 and 94.

Culture and Faith

- Use the guidance in **Cultural Considerations** (Engage): respect different norms, but never let fear of seeming culturally insensitive stop you acting.
- Faith is neither an excuse for harm nor a reason for suspicion. Pupils and staff have rights in relation to religion or belief, and the school will still sanction bullying and harassment (KCSIE 2026, para 279).
- Where so-called honour-based abuse or forced marriage is possible, speak to the DSL straight away and do not contact the family or community first.
- Offer independent interpreters. Do not use siblings, friends or community members to interpret a disclosure.

Disability and SEND

- **Disabled children are three times more likely to be abused** than their peers (KCSIE 2026). Disabled girls can face misogyny and disablism together.
- **Don't put signs of harm down to the condition.** KCSIE warns that changes in behaviour, mood or injury may be assumed to relate to a child's needs without further exploration.
- **Communication barriers** can stop a child telling you, or recognising that what is happening is abuse. Use their usual communication methods, visual supports and extra time, and check understanding.

- **Fact and fiction online:** KCSIE notes some children may find it hard to tell fact from fiction in online content, and repeat it at school. A student with SEND repeating misogynistic content may need explicit teaching, not only a sanction.
- **Involve the SENCO.** KCSIE expects close liaison between the DSL and the SENCO where a report involves a child with SEND (para 250), whether they have been harmed or have caused harm.

KCSIE 2026, paras 249 to 251 and 532.

Sexuality

- Being lesbian, gay or bisexual is **not in itself a risk factor**, but these students can be vulnerable to discriminatory bullying, and a student who is **perceived** to be lesbian, gay or bisexual can be just as vulnerable (KCSIE 2026, para 253).
- **Homophobia polices masculinity:** "gay" and "girl" used as insults punish boys who show emotion or don't fit the "alpha" mould. Challenge both the homophobia and the misogyny underneath it.
- Lesbian and bisexual girls may face sexualised harassment about their sexuality.
- **Treat information about a student's sexuality as sensitive.** Don't share it beyond what is needed to keep them safe; talk to the DSL before anyone else is told, including parents.

Gender-Questioning Students

- KCSIE asks schools to stay aware of the potential vulnerabilities of children who are questioning their gender, including discriminatory bullying (para 257), and to be respectful places where bullying is never tolerated (para 259).
- Harassment of a gender-questioning or trans student, or of a student perceived to be, is child-on-child abuse and must be challenged like any other. The RSHE statutory guidance is clear that people with the protected characteristic of gender reassignment have protection from discrimination and should be treated with respect and dignity (para 69).
- This guide is about harassment and abuse. Requests relating to social transition follow the school's policy and KCSIE 2026, and are not decided by individual staff.

Fairness Check (Pause)

- ✓ Would I respond in the same way if the students involved were of a different race, sex, faith or sexuality, or did not have SEND?
- ✓ Is anything about the victim's identity making me more, or less, likely to believe them?
- ✓ Is the sanction consistent with what other students have received for similar behaviour?
- ✓ Leaders: review incident and sanction data by group each term, and act on any pattern.

Staff Training Requirements

All-Staff VAWG Training

KCSIE requires safeguarding and child protection training at induction, regularly updated, with updates at least annually. It does not require a separate annual VAWG module. School standard, not statutory Annual VAWG training covering:

- ✓ VAWG definition and prevalence
- ✓ School's role in VAWG prevention
- ✓ Recognition of VAWG indicators
- ✓ Immediate response procedures
- ✓ RESPOND framework with VAWG lens
- ✓ Reporting pathways and timescales
- ✓ Support resources for students and staff
- ✓ What to do when a member of staff is targeted, and the school's duty to prevent sexual harassment of staff
- ✓ Legal obligations under KCSIE 2026 and the Equality Act 2010

RSHE Delivery (Teaching Staff)

Training for staff delivering RSHE should cover:

- How to discuss consent effectively
- Dangers of sharing intimate images
- Recognising concerning attitudes (incel ideology, misogyny)
- Responding to curriculum-led disclosures
- Challenging harmful myths about masculinity without stigmatising boys
- Creating safe learning environments
- Handling difficult questions

DSL Enhanced Training

- Advanced VAWG safeguarding
- Multi-agency VAWG pathways and coordination
- Risk assessment for VAWG (including the SafeLives young people's DASH where teenage relationship abuse is involved)
- Working with specialist VAWG services
- Police liaison for sexual offences
- MARAC processes (Multi-Agency Risk Assessment Conference for domestic abuse; victims aged 16+)
- Managing risk from, and supporting, children who display harmful behaviour
- Victim/survivor advocacy and trauma-informed practice

Monitoring Effectiveness

Key Performance Indicators

Culture Indicators:

- ✓ Reduction in sexist language incidents
- ✓ Increase in VAWG reporting (showing confidence in systems)
- ✓ Bystander intervention observed
- ✓ Student voice on safety improvements
- ✓ Staff confidence in VAWG response
- ✓ Incidents of misogyny directed at staff tracked and falling; staff survey shows staff feel supported when targeted

Educational Outcomes:

- ✓ RSHE curriculum fully implements VAWG content
- ✓ Student knowledge assessment shows understanding
- ✓ Consent education evaluation positive
- ✓ Critical thinking about gender stereotypes demonstrated

Support Outcomes:

- ✓ Victims/survivors feel supported (feedback surveys)
- ✓ Timely access to specialist services
- ✓ Safety plans effective
- ✓ Behaviour change evidenced for students who displayed harmful behaviour

RESPOND Student Guides

- Student Guide 101 - 11 to 14: *Respect, Sexism and Misogyny*
- Student Guide 101 - 14 to 18: *Misogyny, Sexual Harassment and Healthy Relationships*

For students to read themselves, or for tutor time and PSHE. Both point students to the DSL team, the school nurse or health centre and national helplines.

RESPOND Parent Guide

- Parent Guide 101 - Ages 4 to 18: *Misogyny and Online Influence: A Guide for Parents*

What misogyny can look like at different ages, online influence, how to talk about it at home, what to do if a child tells them something, and how the school works with families.

Specialist Organisations

VAWG Support Services

- **Women's Aid:** Resources and training - www.womensaid.org.uk
- **Rape Crisis England & Wales:** Information, 24/7 support line and local centres (16+) - www.rapecrisis.org.uk
- **Refuge:** Educational resources, family support, training - www.refuge.org.uk
- **End Violence Against Women Coalition:** Research, campaigns, best practice - www.endviolenceagainstwomen.org.uk
- **Respect:** Young people's programmes and behaviour change - www.respect.uk.net

Curriculum Resources

- **PSHE Association:** VAWG teaching resources, RSHE guidance - www.pshe-association.org.uk
- **Sex Education Forum:** Consent education, healthy relationships - www.sexeducationforum.org.uk
- **Tender (Arts-Based):** Healthy relationships workshops, theatre - www.tender.org.uk
- **Mentors in Violence Prevention:** Bystander training

Government Resources

- ***Freedom from violence and abuse (December 2025):***
www.gov.uk/government/publications/freedom-from-violence-and-abuse-a-cross-government-strategy
- **KCSIE 2026:** Keeping Children Safe in Education statutory guidance
- **RSHE (July 2025):** Relationships, Sex and Health Education statutory guidance, in force September 2026
- **Working Together to Safeguard Children 2026:** Multi-agency safeguarding arrangements
- **UKCIS:** Sharing nudes and semi-nudes: advice for education settings

Quality Assurance Checklist

Immediate Response Quality

- ✓ Behaviour interrupted promptly where safe to do so, or help sought where it was not
- ✓ Issue clearly named as misogyny/VAWG
- ✓ Targeted student supported and safety ensured
- ✓ DSL informed in line with school policy timescales
- ✓ Factual documentation completed
- ✓ No personal investigation undertaken
- ✓ Trauma-informed approach maintained
- ✓ Cultural sensitivity demonstrated
- ✓ Legal obligations understood and met

Follow-Up Quality

- ✓ Individual support plans in place for victim/survivor
- ✓ Educational or restorative intervention for the student who displayed the behaviour
- ✓ Family engagement appropriate and timely
- ✓ Monitoring and review scheduled
- ✓ Systemic factors addressed
- ✓ Staff debrief and support provided, including for any member of staff who was targeted
- ✓ Learning integrated into practice
- ✓ Prevention measures strengthened

Quick Reference Card

Immediate Danger Comes First

Immediate danger or possible risk to life: call 999 when it is needed, stay with the child, and summon the DSL or a deputy. Don't delay action to work through the steps. The 90-second Pause is for once immediate safety is secured, to stop an impulsive or investigative response.

If You Observe Misogynistic Behaviour

1. ✓ **If it is safe to do so, interrupt and clearly name the issue:** "That language/behaviour is misogynistic"
2. ✓ **If it is not safe:** do not confront. Get another adult or use on-call; call 999 if anyone is in immediate danger
3. ✓ **Ensure safety of targeted student:** Move them away from the situation if it is safe to do so
4. ✓ **Note exact language/actions:** Verbatim quotes essential
5. ✓ **Report to the DSL** as soon as is practicably possible: straight away if a child is at risk
6. ✓ **Document factually:** Date, time, who, what, where, impact

If a Student Discloses Harassment/VAWG

1. ✓ **Thank them for telling you:** "Thank you for trusting me with this"
2. ✓ **Believe them and take it seriously:** "I believe you, and I'm taking what you've told me seriously"
3. ✓ **Use TED:** Tell me, Explain, Describe. Never ask "why"
4. ✓ **Validate their experience:** "This was not your fault"
5. ✓ **Explain you must report to DSL:** "I need to report this to keep you safe"
6. ✓ **Don't investigate or ask leading questions:** Listen, don't interrogate
7. ✓ **Provide immediate support:** Safe space, reassurance, dignity
8. ✓ **Document using their exact words:** Direct quotes in quotation marks

RED FLAGS Requiring Immediate Escalation

- 🚨 Threats of violence or sexual violence

-  Evidence of organised harassment campaign
-  Support for, or intent to commit, violence against women and girls (including glorifying incel-related attacks)
-  Nudes or semi-nudes involving a child (do not view, copy or forward)
-  Indicators of adult grooming/exploitation
-  Student at immediate risk of harm
-  Serious sexual assault/violence
-  So-called honour-based abuse concerns

Call DSL immediately. If unavailable and risk is immediate, call 999.

What NOT to Do

-  Don't minimise as "banter" or "just joking"
-  Don't investigate yourself
-  Don't search phones yourself, or view, copy or forward nude or semi-nude imagery; follow DSL direction for preserving other online evidence
-  Don't contact parents before consulting DSL
-  Don't promise confidentiality
-  Don't victim-blame ("What were you wearing?")
-  Don't use "boys will be boys" language
-  Don't delay reporting to DSL

Emergency Contacts

- **Police / Ambulance / Fire: 999**
- **Police Non-Emergency: 101**
- **Your DSL and deputies:** named in your school's safeguarding policy, including out-of-hours on-call
- **Local authority children's services:** front door in hours; emergency duty team out of hours
- **LADO:** through your local authority, for concerns about staff
- **Nearest SARC:** NHS SARC finder
- **National Domestic Abuse Helpline (24/7): 0808 2000 247**
- Full list: see Notify, Your School and Local Contacts
- **Childline: 0800 1111**
- **Rape Crisis (24/7, ages 16+): 0808 500 2222**

- **National Domestic Abuse Helpline (24/7):** 0808 2000 247
- **NSPCC Helpline (adults worried about a child):** 0808 800 5000, 10am to 4pm, Monday to Friday

Online Evidence: One Rule

- **Ordinary messages or posts a student has already shown you:** note what is relevant (platform, date, who, exact words) in your record. Don't ask to see more or scroll through a phone, especially where messages may be sexual, because they may contain images. Don't log in to accounts, search profiles or investigate, and never transfer anything to a personal device.
- **Nude or semi-nude images of anyone under 18:** don't intentionally view, copy, screenshot, forward, save or delete them. Tell the DSL straight away. If you see one by accident, tell the DSL, ask for support if you need it, and record that it was seen and what you did, without describing the image (UKCIS).
- The DSL decides what happens to devices and content.

Your School's Contacts

This guide is generic. Schools add their own details here, or keep a completed copy with this card, so that anyone responding, including at night, has the routes to hand.

Contact	Name and how to reach them
Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL)	
Deputy DSL(s)	
Out-of-hours and boarding on-call safeguarding contact	
How to record a concern (system or form)	
Local authority children's services front door	
Out-of-hours emergency duty team	
LADO (concerns about adults)	
Police: 999 (emergency); 101 (non-emergency)	

RESPOND Safeguarding Framework Reference Scenarios · Staff Guide 101

Scenario 101: Misogyny and Violence Against Women and Girls (VAWG)

© 2026/27 | **RESPOND** Safeguarding Framework

Aligned with: KCSIE 2026 | Working Together to Safeguard Children 2026 | *Freedom from violence and abuse* (December 2025) | RSHE statutory guidance (published July 2025; statutory from September 2026) | Equality Act 2010

Last Updated: September 2026 | Next Review: September 2027, or on publication of KCSIE 2027 if sooner

For staff in schools and other settings working with children. You may share it with colleagues. Share the student and parent guides, not this page, with students and families.